political affectation.' However, in discounting China as a major power and in his Russian fixation, Curzon was to lay his entire emphasis on the wrong country. 'If we do nothing in Tibet we shall have Russia trying to establish a protectorate in less than ten years… This might not constitute a military danger, at any rate for some time, but would be a political danger. The effect on Nepal, Sikkim and Bhutan would constitute a positive danger. We can stop a Russian protectorate over Tibet by being in advance ourselves.'

After Colonel Younghusband's expedition into Lhasa in 1904 had forced the reluctant Tibetans to trade with the British, the border between Tibet and Sikkim was demarcated. In 1913, the Morshead–Bailey expedition was sent to the Tibet-NEFA border to study and map the watershed from the Tibetan side. Both the Chinese and the Tibetan authorities were fully aware of the survey. The following year, when the McMahon Line was drawn up in Simla, the Tibetan representative, Lonchen Gaden Shatra Paljor Dorje, accepted the geographic and demographic arguments of the British based on the expedition's detailed findings. It is also an undisputed fact that Lonchen Shatra had the prior approval of both the thirteenth Dalai Lama and the Tibetan Kashag to help draw up and then accept the McMahon Line.

INDO-TIBET BOUNDARY (WESTERN SECTOR)

The Indo-Tibet boundary was always going to be a problem. Apart from its vastness—extending from the Karakorams in the west to the Lohit River in the east—the actual demarcation had rarely been done. Neither the Tibetans nor the people living in various kingdoms to the south used geographic contours, instead they demarcated regions based on the needs of the people. For example, the Tibetans grazed their yaks and upland sheep in the higher reaches, while the Bhutanese harvested the bamboo that grew at lower altitudes.

But with the twentieth century came modern mapping techniques that began to delineate frontiers on more specific lines. To further complicate the issue, the definition of Tibet itself was somewhat vague; political Tibet (lands controlled by Lhasa) was considerably smaller than its ethnographic counterpart which was close to 2,080,000 square kilometres (almost the size of present-day India).

The majority of the Tibetan population at the time lived in the districts between Lhasa and the Chinese border, but the rest of the country was